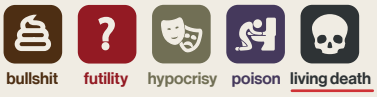
Wage Slavery Degrades Your Weird Beam



Raising awareness of the enervating, clogging, bitter brain-fat and slow, imperceptible soul-death that results from all employment; including forced schooling, participating in the market as a business-owner... and even fun!

'It is difficult to get a man to understand something, when his salary depends upon his not understanding it.'
Upton Sinclair

Introduction

The difference between wage-slavery and slavery is exactly the same difference as that between work and prison. Work is 'better' than prison in that one is 'free' to leave one's job and find another, or to set up one's own business. But in a world totally dominated by a money-economy, where land and the means of production are owned by enormous unaccountable organisations and the parasitic elites which manage them, you are either forced to sell your time, energy and creative power or, if you set up your own business, to suppress your humanity in order to survive in the massively over-expanded, profit-dependent debt-economy. As with voting, you can choose your tyrant, but they all serve the same system.

It wasn't always this way. Money did not replace barter, people did not die in their thirties, or have to huddle terrified in caves, alone in a hostile universe. There were threats, dangers and terrible difficulties, of course, but before civilisation (i.e. before agriculture) we were—as is widely recognised in anthropology—healthy, free and engaged in what we could call work for less than twenty hours a week. Even in the much-caricatured 'dark-ages' usury was a sin, men and women did non-alienating, clock-free, sense-rich work, enjoyed enormous amounts of free time, had free access to rich public commons and had sane ideas of death, madness and the body. But, just as many people like to think that an enormous consensus amongst climate scientists that we are in the middle of a vast ecological disaster is the result of a liberal conspiracy, so many like to believe that the colossal evidence that life was once good and can be again is a wishy-washy hippy dream. They don't believe this because it is true, but because their wages depend on it.

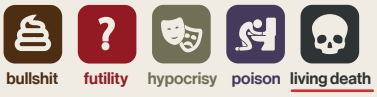
Work Destroys The Bellymind

What is the effect of spending your forty most creative and energetic hours doing the same meaningless task over and over again? What is the effect of suppressing your urge to do as you please every day of your life, of forcing yourself to move, act, sit and speak in ways alien to your nature and to your instincts, to kowtow to your moral and intellectual inferiors, to repress instincts to rebel and to delight, to deny the rending impulse to be irrationally generous and to subordinate the whisperings of your conscience to the unspoken ideology of the workplace? In short: what is the effect of wage-slavery?

The problem is that to those who have done this all their lives (since they started school); who are, for example, unable to speak five languages fluently, dance a-deux with expert grace, build or maintain their own house, grow their own vegetables, paint, act, stitch, ride a horse *and* practice kung-fu to a high level, who do not have the time, energy or inclination to make spectacular love to their wives for several hours a day, to play marvellous non-electronic games with their children and teach them weird tricks, to walk aimlessly in sympathetic forests, to cook elaborate pastries, ponder counterpoint *and* write a brilliant, inquisitive, massively well-informed poetic and comic ten-page letter to a friend, who have to cram such activities into a couple of knackered hours at the end of a degrading, exhausting and reality-deforming commute; to such people there is no meaningful answer to the question of what they have lost, because anything inside them that might be able to understand what it might be speaks such a dim and distant whisper it can no longer be heard. In fact, worse than this—it's a *threat*.

After twenty years of schooling and then ten or twenty years of work, of total servitude to a system which feeds, clothes and houses them, which tells them what to do and which is predictable and safe, free time becomes so terrifying that they must either fill it up with *fun* or with more *business*. The moment a lacuna of unstructured time opens up, the wage-slave invariably throws alcohol down his neck, hurtles around the world taking photographs, turns on the playstation or, most pitifully of all, sets about creating precisely the same kind of exploitative organisation that he has freed himself from.

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'Our society resembles the ultimate machine which I once saw in a New York toy shop. It was a metal casket which, when you touched a switch, snapped open to reveal a mechanical hand. Chromed fingers reached out for the lid, pulled it down, and locked it from the inside. It was a box; you expected to be able to take something out of it; yet all it contained was a mechanism for closing the cover.'

Ivan Illich

'Everyone—executives, physicians, waiters, or whatever—playacts, manipulates, in order to avoid being manipulated and in order to avoid self-threatening exposure. The aim is the protection or promotion of the self, but since that self is in fact cut off from any meaningful intercourse, it suffocates. The environment becomes increasingly unreal as human beings distance themselves from the events of their own lives. As this process accelerates, the self begins to fight back, to nag itself (and create a further split) about the existential guilt it has come to feel. We come to be haunted by our phoniness, our playacting, our flight from trying to become what we truly are or could be. As the guilt mounts, we silence the nagging voice with drugs, alcohol, spectator sports—anything to avoid facing the reality of the situation.'

R.D. Laing

'The idea has occurred to me that if one wanted to crush, to annihilate a man utterly, one need only give him work of an absolutely, completely useless and irrational character.'

Fyodor Dostoyevski

Some Seek Freedom...

Others—more sensitive, more alive—can still hear the voice of their conscience. They can feel, in their bones, that work—*all* wage-slavery and *all* market activity—destroys the good. They know that their headaches, outbursts of anger, lack of creativity, permanent underlying sense of anxiety, their impotence and disinterest, their drug-addiction, their functional illiteracy, their dull-aimless dreams and their ever-present needling sense that life is trickling away is partially the result of their imprisonment. Deeper than this they know that it is not 'necessity' that keeps them at work, but insensitivity, fear of uncertainty, lack of spontaneity, atrophied joy, restless emotionality and an inability to stop thinking: in short the acquired *personality* that covers the innate, uniquely creative *character* that struggles to be free underneath.

It is the personality, the false self overlaid from very young onto the genius within that is addicted to work, to business and to fun, that cannot *dare* to imagine a genuinely independent life of free creative enquiry (or read about it) and, in fact, that *thrives* in the most successful wage-slavery organisations. This is why the most stunted, insincere, aggressive or crushed personalities succeed at work and why, if your boss is not a sad, psychopathic half-man, he will be unhappy and slowly dying inside.

...And Those That Seek, Find

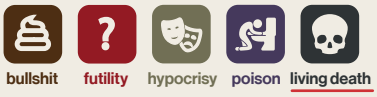
Those that are familiar with the indefinable life inside them, underneath their external personality, are able to detect that it is not anything definable, that they might *know*, which dies at work, but the light of life, which, unknown to the surface thinking personality, slowly dims, leaving the kind of hollow, mechanical late middle-aged shells which drift like ghosts through the workplaces of the world.

You may submit to work for a time, as we all must, to purchase the exchangeable excrement called *money*, but only to buy freedom to escape from this mountain of filth, to get back to digging your tunnel under from out of it a little deeper. Perhaps one day you will escape for good, perhaps not—it's a near impossible task—but it doesn't matter. It is refusing to accept one moment more compromise than is absolutely necessary that keeps the truth alive. *Freedom is not in escape, but in striving to escape.*

Is it really necessary that you spend another year at work? Another two? Ten? Is it really necessary that you work to save up to buy a house or a business so that you end up going back to work again? Is it really necessary that you excuse, in your heart, your hourly denial of your own true nature with rational justifications for this half-life?

If it really is, your half-life will, before you know it, turn you into a half-man or half-woman too.

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Six Ways to Avoid Wage-Slavery

1. Be Born into Wealth

The easiest and by far the most common way to avoid wage slavery altogether is to emerge from a wealthy vagina (i.e. to be *priviliged*). This solution is, of course, impossible if you have already emerged from a unwealthy vagina, but there's no need to fret. To be priviliged is to insulate yourself from the lessons of pain and uncertainty and from the consequences of selfishness, all of which leads to reduced empathy, awareness and sensitivity which in turn leads to increased stupidity, cruelty, crudeness, immaturity and existential horror.

2. Acquire Wealth

A popular solution to living at the mercy of the market-system; but catastrophically flawed. Just as being born into wealth anaesthetizes you from birth so, in acquiring wealth, you must deform yourself, over such a long period of time to fit the needs of the economy that, by the time you do get all those lovely cars and houses, you're utterly incapable of spending your money creatively and deeply, deeply miserable.

3. Become Famous

Another common but problematic solution. If you are genuinely creative, aware and free-minded then fame offers you the power to do what you are inspired to do, without having to check, first, if the boss approves or if it's likely to benefit some wanker's share-dividend. But it's a *very* big 'if'. Most of the time it is safe, meaningless, derivative, market-friendly drivel that is rewarded with fame. What's more, although a vanishingly few genuinely creative and sensitive free-thinkers do achieve this kind of success, fame nearly always ruins them. They become wealthy, isolated from scenius, used-up caricatures of their former selves.

4. Get a Good Job

A good job is one that is protected from the market, ideally—although very rarely—by a benevolent nutcase (e.g. working for Tony Wilson's Factory Records in the 1980s). A job protected by a reasonably socialist establishment (such as the BBC in the 1970s) is a fair second-choice but still puts catastrophic demands on your time and, through never really being free from the market, on your conscience. Take, for example, working for the NHS in the 1960s—a noble task, for an egalitarian and well-run organisation—and a massive improvement on the market-based health services that came before and after, but *still* deeply embedded in a sickening system and still, on the whole, part of the problem, not part of the solution.

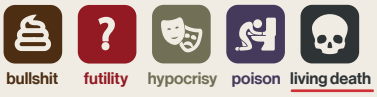
5. Drop out Entirely

At the other end of the wealth-and-fame scale there's the life of the wildman, the monk and the total drop-out. Famous artistic examples include Thoreau, Kerouac and Lee—although they had help from relatives. Less famous examples crop up from time to time of men (usually men) who manage to live in a forest for years, or of Crimethinc style wanderers living from dumpster diving, or of holy men living on alms. This solution, the most extreme, is a 'bit much' for most people. Recommended for heroes and fools only.

6. Do Whatever you Can

The best solution, by far—the most reasonable and practicable—is also the most difficult to describe, because it relies so intimately on your own situation; but in essence, the best way to avoid work is a mixture of scamming, 'stealing' (only from the very wealthy though, or from large organisations) signing on, working temporarily or part time (and then spending your money on freedom), riding your luck (which, in the avatar-form of Captain Unemployment *does* reward worklessness), living off savings, learning to live under the radar and scrounging off friends and relatives. This last one is, of course, only as a last resort, as suckling from parents and friends is profoundly dignity-sapping—sometimes you *have to* bite the bullet.

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Frequently Asked Questions and Commonly Raised Objections

HOW CAN I LIVE WITHOUT MONEY?

You can't. Some hardy, adventurous souls have tried and *almost* completely succeeded, but they inevitably had to return to the market. And sometimes you *have* to work—only a coward shirks his or her responsibilities. The question however, is not how to live naked in a field drinking rain-water, but how to be as free as possible from earning money through wage-slavery. It is possible to live well while working infrequently. You might have to sacrifice many of the pleasures and luxuries you currently enjoy though; notably anxiety and future-dread.

WHAT WOULD I DO WITH MY FREE TIME!?

If you can't handle free time you don't deserve it. If you do not have a bright love of self-development, if your horizons are limited by what you know you like (particularly passive sporting or tourist spectacles, high technology stimulation, money-making and fun purchased through the market) and if you cannot sit still for five minutes without thinking, or looking around for an entertainment device, then you are well suited to wave-slavery.

BUT I'VE GOT CHILDREN! IT WOULD BE IRRESPONSIBLE TO LEAVE MY JOB WHEN I HAVE KIDS TO RAISE.

Do you have a responsibility to compel your children to do what they do not want to do, learn what they do not want to learn, for forty hours a week, so that they might end up being as enslaved as you? Do you have a responsibility to buy your child all the latest gadgets, phones, computers and electronic toys? Do you have a responsibility to bring your child up in a mediated, virtual environment in which *everything* he or she touches or sees has been shaped by human hand? No. You have a responsibility to raise your children in a free, natural environment, to be present for most of the time, while your child grows up and to demonstrate, by your actions, how fearless, versatile and talented a human being can be. Can you do any of this as a wage slave? No. A responsible parent might have to work a little longer than a responsible bachelor to get enough money to live free for a few years, but your wage-slavery can only lead to your child's unhappiness and subordination.

BUT MY JOB IS IMPORTANT! I AM DOING GOOD!

If you are a teacher you are, first of all, serving a corporate syllabus, and you are paid to ensure that your students repress their own experience and spontaneous urges. If you are a doctor your *priority* is to sell drugs, to prevent people from healing (or understanding) their own bodies and to get them back to work. If you are involved in any way in the energy, travel, food, clothing, entertainment, housing, waste-disposal or defence industries you are employed to maximise profits, subordinate individual people into the roles of dependent consumers and clients, separate communities, deprive them of the resources they need to run their own lives, addict them to sickening drugs and shoddy substandard products or, at the very best, clear up the waste that a sick system generates. No matter how good a person you are (and there are many), you will be ignored, ridiculed, or otherwise punished if you put your generosity, conscience or intelligence above these priorities. If your desire for freedom extends into the community—creating networks of free labour exchanges, a gift-economy and occupying the commons—you will be imprisoned or killed. A great deal of energy is expended on justifying, even glorifying this disgusting system, but no good comes of it, only continued—and, for the lucky, merely *comfortable*—existence.

WHERE CAN I READ MORE ABOUT ALL THIS?

For demolishment of professional control of public commons and our dependence on anti-human systems (esp. school and hospital) Ivan Illich is outstanding, although a *bit* heavy going. Bob Black and William Morris both wrote superb short pieces against wage-slavery. Jeff Schmidt, in *Disciplined Minds*, wrote an excellent account of how the university system selects for obedience and how professionalism 'adjusts curiosity.' Ivor Southwood writes well on precarity and the horrors of modern temping. David Frayne has a good book out on *The Refusal of Work*. The best, sweetest and most subversive place to get a whole-view of the problem and the deepest gut-solutions is, I must say, The Apocalypedia.